Sequencing can also be implemented using delegation data rather than durable policy rules. An agent may start a task with permission to read documents and later receive additional authority—such as the ability to send email—only after completing an intermediate step. In this model, authority evolves as the task progresses, and policies evaluate the current state of delegation at runtime.

These approaches illustrate an important principle: authorization in agent systems is not only about enforcing boundaries but also about shaping the path an agent takes. By expressing sequencing constraints in policy or delegation data, systems can ensure that actions occur in the correct order and under the appropriate conditions.

18.5 Childproofing the control plane

As ACME's engineers refined their agent architecture, Trudy raised another concern. The new systems were becoming more capable. Agents could retrieve data, call APIs, and trigger automated workflows across the company's systems.

That capability raised an obvious question: what would prevent an agent from modifying the systems that governed those actions?

In many modern platforms, the same APIs used to perform operational tasks can also alter the system's configuration. These operations make up the system's control plane, the set of tools used to define workflows, manage infrastructure, and configure policies.

If an agent were permitted to freely modify these components, it could potentially weaken the safeguards designed to constrain it.

Trudy emphasized that ACME's engineers should treat the control plane differently from normal operational tools. "We should assume agents will eventually try everything they can," she told the team. "So we need to make sure the important knobs are out of reach."